perfect harmony," he says.

The idea of a grand anti-BJP front is not new. KCR had made strenuous efforts since late 2018 and well into 2019, before the Lok Sabha polls, to build such an alliance. He met prominent opposition leaders across the country, but his 'federal', 'non-BJP, non-Congress' alliance did not materialise. West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee's exertions towards an 'anti-BJP, anti-Congress' front also met the same fate. The Congress, thus, was conspicuous by its absence from their plans. This is where Nitish Kumar crucially differs. His idea of an opposition front—he calls it the 'main front'—involves a rainbow coalition of political parties, including both the Congress and the Left.

OVERALL PLAN FOR A UNIFIED FRONT

Stitching an anti-BJP 'main front' with both the Congress and Left parties on board. The Congress is central to the plan as the grand old party is in direct contest with BJP in 186 Lok Sabha seats

THE DRIVING LOGIC: The BJP in 2019 got about 38 per cent votes nationwide. This means 62 per cent of the electorate still voted against the BJP. The idea is to consolidate these voters as much as possible

TARGET BJP IN THEIR STRONG AREAS: 262 of the 303 seats that the BJP won in 2019, or 87 per cent of its Lok Sabha strength, came from just 12 states, including Bihar

TARGET 200 SEATS WHERE BJP FACES A MAJOR CHALLENGE: These are in Tamil Nadu (39 LS seats), Kerala (20), Telangana (17), Andhra Pradesh (25), Bihar (40), Punjab (13), Odisha (21) and West Bengal (42). Part of the plan is to not cede any ground to the BJP in these states through stitching formidable alliances

PROMINENT ALLIES: Top regional leaders to be featured in the front are Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal, K. Chandrashekar Rao in Telangana, M.K. Stalin in Tamil Nadu, Uddhav Thackeray and Sharad Pawar in Maharashtra, Arvind Kejriwal in Delhi, Akhilesh Yadav in Uttar Pradesh and Tejashwi Yadav in Bihar



Like Lalu and Pawar, Nitish believes that given its pan-India presence, the Congress is important because it was in direct contest with the BJP in nearly 200 seats in both the 2014 and 2019 Lok Sabha polls. As the BJP won most of these seats, it may suffer from some anti-incumbency and with help from regional parties, the Congress can win a good many back. So goes the thinking. At the rally in Fatehabad, he exhorted the leaders on the dais, including some with a strong anti-Congress history, to bury their differences and work for a larger unity.

There is likely to be some focus on expanding the opposition by assimilating diverse social groups with conflicting interests within its fold. The concept is similar to that of UPA-1 and UPA-2, without actually granting or denying leadership to the Congress. Besides, Nitish is opposed to the idea of the Congress backing an alliance from outside, like the United Front that formed two short-lived governments in 1996 and 1998 headed by H.D. Deve Gowda and I.K. Gujral, respectively.

Nitish first mentioned a country-wide anti-BJP *mahagathbandhan* on August 31, when he shared his thoughts on opposition unity with KCR, who visited him in Patna. When a journalist asked KCR about his opinion, Nitish cut in, saying, "It will not be any third front, but the main opposition front." KCR, the votary of a non-BJP-non-Congress alliance, nodded with a smile. KCR, however, has his own plans for uniting the opposition as well as expanding his footprint nationally. In a meeting in Hyderabad on October 5, the Telangana Rashtra Samithi was formally renamed the Bharat Rashtra Samithi. The new party is expected to fight the 2024 polls from several states.

HOPE FOR THE OPPOSITION

On August 9, as Nitish snapped ties with the BJP and formed a government with the RJD, Congress and others, he set off a surge of optimism among opposition parties. He received calls from a cross-section of leaders—while KCR paid a visit, leaders like Mamata Banerjee and Uddhav Thackeray called to express solidarity. Nitish told all of them to help stitch a grand alliance against the BJP. The enthusiasm in the opposition ranks is not without reason. After all, a body blow to the BJP in an electorally important state like Bihar was the one positive since the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. Consider also the demoralising effect of the BJP toppling governments in Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra, as well as five others in the same way since 2014. Seeing the BJP on the receiving end for a change, the schadenfreude was palpable. Besides, a canny actor like Nitish becoming available to the opposition is itself a shift in gravity.

NITISH'S IDEA OF AN OPPOSITION FRONT—HE CALLS IT THE 'MAIN FRONT'—INVOLVES A RAINBOW COALITION, INCLUDING BOTH THE CONGRESS AND THE LEFT PARTIES

During his visit to Delhi during the first week of September, the Bihar CM met Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal, Sharad Pawar, Janata Dal (Secular) leader H.D. Kumaraswamy, Sitaram Yechury, CPI's D. Raja, Om Prakash Chautala and Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav with an idea clearly to create a rainbow alliance against BJP for the 2024 Lok Sabha polls. Almost all discussions Nitish has held with opposition lead-